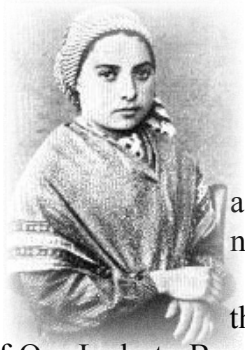


Sentinels of the Dawn

The Newsletter of the Poor Clare Nuns of Perpetual Adoration

Monastère de Notre Dame des Anges Troyes

Spring 2008 Volume I Issue 2



A Tribute to Our Lady of Lourdes:

Celebrating 150 years of Pilgrimage and Grace

In 1844, in the heart of the 19th century, Bernadette Soubirous was born in Lourdes, a little town located in the Pyrenees of France. She grew up in the midst of a poor family of nine children, five of whom died at a young age.

It was on the 11th of February, 1858, while in search of wood for the fireplace at home, that she first met a "beautiful lady" in the hollow of a rock. This was to be the first of 18 apparitions of Our Lady to Bernadette, who would in the course of these encounters reveal herself as "the Immaculate Conception". She would ask Bernadette to "pray for the conversion of sinners," to "go and wash...in the fountain," which had miraculously begun to flow at the grotto and finally to "tell the priests to have a chapel built," where all could come in procession.

Today, 150 years after the apparitions, Lourdes has become a haven for over six million pilgrims who come from all over the world each year to respond to Our Lady's wish. These pilgrims? They are of all ages, of all different nationalities and religions; those who are sick or handicapped, as well as those who accompany them. For all who make a pilgrimage, the grace that is received at Lourdes is unique, singular. For some, Lourdes is a touch of heaven, where the overwhelming presence of the Blessed Virgin Mary is felt; for others it is a place where their purpose in life is found, where a conversion of heart is experienced; and still for others, it a place where "their batteries are recharged". Lourdes is truly a place that speaks to everyone.

As Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration, we ourselves take delight in this jubilee year in Lourdes, for great is our devotion to the Immaculata. The same day that the dogma of the Immaculate Conception was declared in Rome by Pope Pius IX on December 8th, 1854, our Foundress, Mother Marie de Sainte Claire consecrated the first Community of Sisters to the powerful intercession of the Immaculata and our Order was born. Thus, devotion to Our Lady has been passed down from generation to generation. Our dear Mothers and Sisters who come to visit us from our different monasteries throughout the world, have the privilege of going Lourdes themselves, thanking Our Lady for all the graces that are bestowed upon us by Jesus, through her hands.

Throughout the course of this year, we unite ourselves to all those who journey to this holy place, and we pray that they may receive healing, that they will discover their personal vocation -their particular mission as Christians in today's society- and that they may walk hand in hand with Saint Bernadette and Our Lady, along the path of holiness.

Ave, Ave, Ave Maria!

How many candles have been lit in your honor, Mary, "the radiant dawn" who enlightens the darkness that surrounds us. For leading us to the true Light, your Divine Son, we thank you, Mary!

How many have knelt before you in prayer, Mary, uttering your most holy name, you who are "blessed among women." For all the suffering for whom you have interceded, we thank you, Mary!

How many flowers have been placed at your feet, Mary, "enclosed Garden of God". Your purity, your humility, your fidelity permeate our very lives. For all the graces which we have received, we thank you Mary!

Great are the Works of the Lord!

The Gospel of Saint John recounts that it was on the shore of Lake Tiberias that Jesus showed Himself to His disciples for the third time, after rising from the dead. Peter and the other disciples had gone fishing and had caught NOTHING all night. Jesus, who was standing on the shore, not recognized by His followers, calls out to them, "Have you caught anything, friends?" Hearing their discouraged response of "No", Jesus tells them to "cast your nets on the starboard side, and you'll find something." At His request, these weary fishermen dropped their nets and much to their surprise, there were so many fish that they could not haul them all in. It was only then that John, beloved disciple of Jesus, tells Peter, "It is the Lord!"

When the disciples came ashore, they saw that Jesus had prepared a fire and was cooking fish. He invited them to bring some of the fish that *they* had just caught. Was it not the Divine Master who first intervened for them so that they were able to catch these fish? And so it is for us, when it comes to the work that we ourselves begin... we put forth our little efforts and then God blesses them— a hundredfold! How true it is that alone we can do nothing, but with God, all things are possible.

Here at the monastery we "cast our nets" into the hands of our loving Father, asking Him to provide us with a means of supporting ourselves, a communal work that would be conducive to our lives as adorers of the Most Blessed Sacrament. What a catch He has, in turn, provided for us! Brother François Sainte-Marie, a Missionary of the Immaculate Conception of Lourdes, proved to be the instrument in this "catch". This past October, Brother had mentioned to one of our Sisters that many priests on pilgrimage to Lourdes order albs. The demand has become so great, that the supply is lagging far behind. Brother François,who is a professional tailor, asked if we would be interested in sewing them. (It sounds a little like the large quantity of fish caught by the disciples, that they could not haul in, doesn't it?) And with hearts filled with thanksgiving we cried, "It is the Lord!" Like Peter who jumped into the water at the recognition of His Master, so we jumped at the wonderful opportunity to do something beautiful for the Church, for priests.



Madame Mirat laying out the pattern for the servers' albs with her new student.



Brother François oversees the cutting out of our first alb for priests.



Going through the steps of how to assemble an alb with Madame Fleury.



... and we're off and stitching!

Brother very generously offered to come to get us started, but due to his busy schedule, the visit was postponed for several months. So things were put on hold... or so we thought!

God is never outdone in His generosity, and He truly confirmed the work that we wanted to start when we received a phone call with a proposal to sew some albs for altar servers. Once again, the offer was there to show us how to sew them, and we gladly accepted the work. Not long after, Madame Mirat came to the monastery with a large bolt of material, patterns for three different sizes, and a handful of necessary sewing supplies to get us started on our project. Our mission: to complete ten albs for the altar servers of St. Bernard's Parish of Troyes before Easter. Madame Mirat, who is a sewing and cooking teacher, was very generous with her time, especially since her two visits happened to be during school vacation. Her "newest students" listened and watched attentively and then under her encouraging guidance, put forth their best efforts. For some of our Sisters who have only sewn on treadle machines, this was a new adventure. By the grace of God, the work is going well, and the albs, along with the sewing Sisters "seam" to be holding together in one piece! Thank you so much, dear Madame Mirat, for our first order, our first stitches, our first confidence!

The long awaited visit of our good Brother François finally arrived in the last week of February. He brought with him another tailor, Madame Evelyn Fleury, who both gave us a two-day "crash course" on how to sew a particular type of alb that is preferred by many priests in Lourdes. It seems that, despite having to rip out our mistakes a few times, we passed the test with "flying colors" and we now anticipate our first customers. Our hearts are filled with gratitude for the generosity of these two expert sewers who shared their love and knowledge of this great work with us, and helped to get us started in our newest endeavor. We would also like to thank all those who, hearing by word of mouth about our work, have generously contributed much needed items, such as sewing machines, tables, thread, rulers, pins and scissors. We shall sing a hymn of thanksgiving with each stitch...

If Sister is washing, it's gotta be Monday!





Yes, we're still unpacking!

Celebrating Mother's Feast Day, thanking her for all that she does for the good of our Community.



"Working out", in preparation for the the great Solemnity of Easter.



Watch your fingers, Sister!!





Our Sacristan preparing the sacred vessels for Holy Mass with loving care.

In the course of our everyday, still "unordinary" life, we continue to move forward, taking one step at a time. In addition to sewing, cooking and cleaning, each Sister has various tasks to be fulfilled, all of which are necessary and important to our community life as a whole. We desire to make full use of our talents in the work assigned to us, so as to give honor and glory to God. For what have we received that has not been given to us? Our monastic work is looked upon not so much as a burden, but rather, a grace, while we strive to do everything in a peaceful and recollected spirit. Another type of work—mental work— keeps us busy as we continue to learn the French language. One hour each day has been reserved for our studies and twice a week, Brother Claude, a Christian School Brother, and Sister Germaine of the Oblates of Saint Francis de Sales, give our Sisters French lessons, rendering their services and sacrificing their precious time, so that we can speak and write the beautiful French language. May the Lord bless them both.

Sister Germaine with her students who are eager to learn the French language,





Mr. Lequin, a French electrician, hasn't lost his smile despite the difficult task of rewiring the entire monastery.



Merci, Brother Claude, for another interesting French lesson.

We cannot fail to mention, as well, all the wonderful workers who come to the monastery and are helping to make improvements— everything from electricity to plumbing to designs for the renovation of our chapel. We have been blessed to have none other than the parents of Fr. Dominic Mary, MFVA spend two months in Troyes. Mr. Ron Garner, a retired electrician and his wife and faithful assistant, Barb, volunteered to help a local French electrician re-wire the entire monastery. In dismantling the old system, they have repeatedly said that it's a miracle that this old house escaped a fire. Another problem was discovered when we received a sky-high water bill: an underground leak! Not all is disheartening news, however. Fruit trees were pruned and old tree stumps were removed in our garden, in anticipation of the spring planting season. Work united with prayer - these are our constant companions.

Our zealous volunteers were first "stumped" by the stubborn roots of this old tree, but perservance and muscle paid off.





Thanks to Mr. Garner, things are looking brighter!

With whatever work we set out to accomplish, whether great or small, seen or unseen, we take the words of St. Paul to the Colossians as our motto: "Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as though you were working for the Lord, and not for men. Remember that the Lord will reward you; you will receive what He has kept for His people. For Christ is the real Master you serve." (Col. 3: 23-24) We trust that He Himself will work wonders through His servants, as we "cast out our nets" with each passing day. May God bless all of you, who participate so generously in our work, and all who by their friendship and encouragement--- spiritual and material--- help us to fulfill our vocation.



Our guard dog, Ma Belle, finishes her rounds and hopes for a treat.



Mrs. Garner's gentle and willing spirit warmed our hearts.

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Welcoming our Visitors with open arms and hearts

Time has passed so quickly that it's hard to believe we have reached our six month mark since our arrival in Troyes. Looking back upon all that has occurred, we give thanks to God for all the abundant blessings that He has bestowed upon us. One of the many blessings has been the visit of some of our Franciscan brothers and sisters who have travelled great distances to spend time with our community, along with visits from relatives and friends. We are grateful for the sacrifices they have made to "come and see" the cradle monastery of our Order, as well as for their generosity and eagerness to help us in various ways. These visits have been a source of great encouragement to each one of us, and a manifestation of God's Divine Providence, as we enjoyed being in one another's presence, sharing moments of laughter and tears.

There have been other "visits" as well, frequently received through the letters and care packages sent by those near and dear to our hearts, for which we are equally grateful. How our hearts rejoice to be in contact with so many correspondents from around the world.

Last, but not least, we recall our daily visits to the Most Blessed Sacrament, where we gather together in a spiritual manner with all our brothers and sisters throughout the world, for there is "no distance between two tabernacles". May we always remain united in His Eucharistic Presence, loving, adoring and singing His praises ....

Adoremus in Aeternum Sanctissimum Sacramentum!



Fr. Bill McIntyre, a Maryknoll Missionary serving in Bangladesh, was our very first visitor, bringing with him "tidings of great joy!"



Fr. Dominic Mary with Brs. Bernadine Mary & Bernard Mary, Missionaries of the Eternal Word, proved to be a BIG help for us this past October. Thanks for your hard work!



Srs. Mary Francis Sharbel & Mary Peter from Hanceville, Alabama re-unite with three of their Sisters at the Cradle Monastery, after their pilgrimage to Lourdes this past October.



Our community was blessed to have Mother Mary Angela, Abbess of our monastery in Washington, D.C. in our midst for a few days in January. Thanks for all the cooking & sacristy tips, dear Mother!



Still "flying high" after their pilgrimage to Lourdes for Our Lady's Feast on the 11th of February, Srs. Marie Emmanuel & Maria Concepta spent a week in Troyes before returning to Hanceville, AL.